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S.F. Sen. Scott Wiener says cease-fire protestors ‘crossed lines’ during recent interactions

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State Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, has been accosted in public multiple times in recent weeks by activists calling for Israel to cease its bombing in Gaza.

A video put together by the Jewish Community Relations Council Bay Area circulating on social media shows protesters approaching Wiener and accusing him of sending money to Israel and supporting genocide. The video is a compilation of clips filmed by protesters following and yelling at Wiener.

Several of the clips show activists yelling at Wiener during an event at the California Academy of Sciences in Golden Gate Park on Friday evening, Wiener told the Chronicle.

A clip taken that night shows a crowd of activists surrounding a car Wiener is in. A person wearing a black and white checkered scarf to symbolize solidarity with Palestinians yells into a microphone, "You're funding genocide! Genocide profiteer!" at Wiener as he sits in the car. "You're killing babies, Scott. Shame on you. Wiener, Wiener, you can't hide. We charge you with genocide."

Wiener and other members of the California Legislature do not have an official role in U.S. foreign policy and do not control whether the federal government sends aid to Israel.

Wiener said the protesters encircled the car as he and a staffer tried to leave the event on Friday. In the clip, police officers move protesters back from the car so Wiener can drive away.

"It was a very scary situation for not just me but my young staffer to be surrounded and blockaded like that," he said. "It required police intervention."

In another clip, a man approaches Wiener as he is exiting a plane at an airport saying, "Free Palestine, weak-ass Zionist."

Wiener said the video was taken in December at the airport in Phoenix.

The man follows Wiener as he makes his way through the airport. "Anything?" he asks. "You just a coward, bruh. Your whole bloodline's cowards."

Wiener said he felt threatened by the man, who followed him through the airport.

Wiener, an outspoken Democrat, has long drawn the ire of the far right, and has previously been targeted with death threats and bomb threats at his home. Since the war began in Gaza, he has continued to publicly discuss his views on the conflict, openly condemning the Oct. 7 attack by Hamas and also harshly criticizing Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and his bombing campaign in Gaza.

"I'm used to being protested, I'm used to being criticized," he told the Chronicle. "People have every right to criticize me or any other elected official on any issue, but there are lines that can be crossed and both of these situations crossed lines."

Wiener was also singled out by some activists last month during a protest at the California Capitol that shut down the first day of the legislative session in the state Assembly. Some of the protesters chanted about Wiener specifically, accusing him of genocide. Asked about the chant, Wiener told reporters gathered at the Capitol that the

accusation was "disgusting and false."

"I've made it clear that Benjamin Netanyahu and his government should be replaced," he said. "I have publicly said I want the war to end, and that Israel needs to be more surgical in targeting Hamas because so many civilians are dying."

Wiener said he and other Jewish lawmakers have their own criticisms of Israel and want the war to end, but don't support a cease-fire resolution.

"The death that happened in Israel, the death that's happening in Gaza — it's just horrific," he told reporters outside the Senate chambers, just around the corner from where the singing protesters had filled the rotunda. "We also know that the cease-fire resolutions we've seen at the local level have at times gone off the rails in terms of dredging up a lot of anti-Jewish hate, and that causes a lot of fear in our community for a nonbinding resolution."

Wiener and Assembly Member Jesse Gabriel, co-chairs of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, said that last month the governor's Office of Emergency Services briefed them on more than 200 bomb threats that had been made against Jewish institutions since the Oct. 7 attack. Gabriel, a Democrat from Encino, said it's a particularly scary time for the Jewish community, which faces attacks from both the far left and the far right.

The United States has continued to be a staunch ally of Israel since Hamas attacked the country on Oct. 7, killing about 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and taking about 240 hostages, according to Israel. Many of the hostages are still in Gaza.

In response, Israel has launched an intense bombing campaign in the territory, which has killed more than 28,000 people, mostly women and minors, according to local health officials.

Biden has grown critical of the Israeli offensive in Gaza, saying it needs to more narrowly target Hamas fighters. But despite the criticism, Biden has continued to approve arms sales to Israel and is urging Congress to send more aid.

The Associated Press contributed reporting.

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